> and the shouts of ‘Halt, Halt, keep back the cavalry,’ were incessant. Just after getting clear of the Pass – I with great difficulty made my way to the front. We had not gone far in the dark before I found myself surrounded. At this moment my Khidmutgar [table servant] rushed up to me, saying he was wounded, had lost his pony, and begged me to take him up. I had not time to do so before I was pulled off my horse and knocked down by a blow on the head from an Afghan knife, which must have killed me had I not placed a portion of Blackwood’s Magazine in my forage cap. As it was a piece of bone about the size of a wafer was cut from my skull, and I was nearly stunned. I managed to rise upon my knees, and seeing that a second blow was coming I met it with the edge of my sword, and I suppose cut off some of my assailant’s fingers, as the knife fell to the ground. He bolted one way, and I the other, minus my cap. The Khidmutgar was dead; those who had been with me I never saw again. I rejoined our troops, scrambled over a barricade of trees made across the Pass, and I got a severe blow on the shoulder from an Afghan who rushed down the hill and across the road.[58]

The badly wounded Brydon was saved by clinging to the stirrup of an officer’s horse, and so was dragged clear of the mêlée. Stumbling over more corpses in the moonlight, he then came across a mortally wounded cavalryman. He had been shot through the chest, and was haemorrhaging blood over his scarlet uniform. The man grabbed Brydon by the hand and begged him to take his pony before someone else did. The cavalryman then fell back dead. Grateful to his anonymous benefactor, and desperate to find any other last survivors, Brydon mounted the pony and rode off into the darkness.

There were a few other miraculous escapes. Havildar Moti Ram, one of the last survivors of the Charikar Gurkha garrison, who had been enslaved on arrival in Kabul, heard that the garrison was leaving the Kabul cantonment and managed to effect a further escape from his captors on the night of 6 January.

Pretending to the Afghans who stopped him that he was a camel driver discharged from the service of Shah Shuja, he managed to find the stone under which he had buried his life savings and rejoined his colleagues just in time to be present for the massacre in the Khord Kabul Pass two days later. ‘At Jagdalak,’ he later recorded,

> the British force was girded round by Akbar Khan’s horsemen, who killed all they could. In the darkness I extricated myself from this scene of carnage, and sought safety once more in the hilltops. I remained a day high up in the hills. I had tasted no food for twenty-six hours from the time I made my last insufficient meal. I was benumbed by cold . . . I wished for death to release